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Sales Officer

Hails from Bhagalpur, a small town in Bihar. Joined SMILE Foundation for basic computer literacy, spoken English and other soft skills for job interviews and group discussions.



"It was the SMILE Foundation which helped me get proper training and job assistance after I came to Delhi."

in both urban and rural areas. Our courses can prepare youth for white- and blue-collar jobs."

The country may boast of an enviable demography, but only 11 of the 100 students in schools actually graduate. According to Union Human Resources Minister Kapil Sibal, there are 547 million people under 20 years of age in India and only 11 per cent of them will become graduates. He calls it a recipe for disaster, as the rate of school dropout is 39 per cent. Explains Nalini Gangadharan, CEO of CAP Foundation, a public-private partnership that focuses on providing education that makes young people employable: "Our education system does not respond to the needs of a vulnerable population, which feels the need to earn a livelihood after 14 or 15 years of age. It fails to provide life skills that are linked to the employment market."

In order to plug this gap, vocational training institutes like GRAS Academy and NGOs like CAP and

Pratham are coming forward to strengthen the talent pipeline. As wage inflation makes business expansion a tough proposition, corporate India is engaging with NGOs, vocational training institutes and the Government to focus on making India's youth more employable and formulate courses suited to industry needs. Philanthropy is no longer about writing a cheque, but about investing in the future.

If India is to grow at a steady clip, it will require a steady stream of manpower. Conservative estimates show that the numbers are imposing. By the year 2010, the BPO industry will employ 23 lakh people, while organised retail will create two million new jobs. Travel and hospitality will require an additional one lakh people every year. Explains H.N. Shrinivas, vice-president, human resources, at Indian Hotels: "The bad days are over for the hospitality industry and we are looking at growth again. This will require skilled manpower, for which

we are tying up with several institutions that will train workforce at the entry level, as we are opening at least six new hotels each year."

While some institutions are going ahead and offering industry-specific courses, like Pratham which has a tie-up with Godrej Agrovet, Larsen & Toubro, Deutsche Bank and Taj Hotels, many others offer generic courses that prepare rural youth for the service industry. In fact, the Government's attempts to modernise the ITIs have also gained momentum now. In 2005, the Government decided to upgrade around 1,400 government-run ITIs to centres of excellence in specific trades and skills. For this, public-private partnerships (PPP) were launched under which 600 firms signed memoranda of understanding (MOUs) with state governments for the PPP model. The CII has adopted 236 ITIs in the country and is ensuring that these become centres of excellence that serve specific manpower requirements of industries.

For instance, Indian Hotels identified sustainable livelihoods as a theme for their corporate social responsibility projects. The hotel chain is seeking to bridge the 'divide' be-

Pratham Foundation

Under the PACE programme, disadvantaged youth in the 18-30 age group are given vocational training for banking, agriculture, hospitality and construction. For this, it has tied up with many corporates.

Number of centres: 7

Present in: Maharashtra

